

Chinese Checkers — Game Rules

Objective

Move all 10 of your pieces from your starting triangle into your goal triangle on the opposite side of the board before your opponents do.

Board

The board is a six-pointed star made up of hexagonal cells. Each point of the star is a triangle of 10 cells. In a 2-player game, players occupy opposite points. In 3, 4, and 6-player games, players are distributed symmetrically around the star.

Turn Structure

Players take turns in order. On your turn you must move exactly one piece. You may not pass your turn.

Movement

On each turn a piece may either **slide** or **hop**:

Slide — move one step to any directly adjacent empty cell.

Hop — jump over an adjacent piece (yours or any opponent's) to the empty cell immediately on the other side. The piece that is hopped over is not removed from the board.

Hop chains — after completing a hop, you may continue hopping with the same piece as many times as possible in a single turn, or stop at any intermediate landing cell. Choosing where to stop is part of your strategy.

Your Goal Triangle

Your goal triangle is the point of the star directly opposite your starting triangle. Getting pieces there efficiently is the core challenge of the game.

Once a piece enters **your own** goal triangle it **may not leave**. Attempting to move a piece out of your own goal triangle ends your game immediately by forfeit.

A hop chain that enters your own goal triangle mid-chain and then exits again in the same move is also illegal and results in an immediate forfeit. Plan your hop chains carefully.

Moving Through Opponent Triangles

Pieces may move freely through any triangle on the board that is not your own goal — including opponent starting triangles and opponent goal triangles. A piece passing through or temporarily sitting in an opponent's triangle can move out again normally on a future turn.

Note: In a 2-player game, your opponent's starting triangle is your goal triangle and vice versa. In multi-player games the triangles rotate symmetrically. Only your own designated goal triangle applies the no-exit restriction.

Blocking

Leaving pieces parked inside an opponent's goal triangle is a valid tactic — it prevents that opponent from completing their goal in those cells. However, it carries risk (see the [Swap Rule](#) below) and leaves fewer pieces available to race to your own goal.

The Swap Rule

If **all** of the following are true on your turn:

- Every cell in your goal triangle is occupied
- At least one of those occupied cells contains an opponent's piece
- You have no legal move that places one of your pieces into your goal triangle
- You have at least one piece immediately adjacent to your goal triangle (touching the boundary)

Then you may **swap**: one of your adjacent pieces teleports directly into any opponent-occupied goal cell, and the opponent's piece is placed on the cell your piece just vacated. The evicted piece is free to move normally on subsequent turns. This counts as your entire turn. If this completes your goal, you win immediately.

The swap is available once per turn and removes one blocking piece at a time.

Winning

You win the moment all 10 of your pieces occupy your goal triangle. This can be triggered by a normal move or a swap move.

Forfeiting

The following actions end your game immediately by forfeit — your pieces remain on the board for the rest of the game (if it's a multi-player game):

- Moving a piece out of **your own** goal triangle
 - Making a hop chain that enters your own goal triangle and exits again in the same move
 - Submitting any physically illegal move (moving to an occupied cell, moving a piece that isn't yours, moving off the board, etc.)
 - Returning None as your move
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Time Limit

There is no time limit set for any given move or game. But there is a time limit on the grading and future planned tournaments that limit the amount of overall game play, so the agent must be efficient to acquire the most points that it can within the constraints.

Notes for Agent Developers

- You receive a **read-only snapshot** of the game state each turn. You may not modify the game state directly.
- Your snapshot includes your goal triangle, starting positions, all piece locations, and the move history.
- Legal moves are provided for your convenience but it is **your responsibility** to avoid submitting moves that violate goal-exit or goal-transit rules — those moves appear in the legal move list since the engine only checks physical reachability.
- The swap move will appear in your legal move list when all conditions are met. It is represented as a standard (start, end) tuple where end is occupied by an opponent piece inside your goal.